the terms of their agreements when desired.[5] These Asian nations had spent decades negotiating between their two powerful imperial neighbours, and were thus astute Great Game players. By 1922 and 1923, the survival instincts of the rulers of Persia and Afghanistan had become even more potent given their need to appease growing nationalist and pan-Islamic feeling among their people. Indeed, in a somewhat ironic twist, it was ultimately the intensification of these movements in the post-war years that actually helped prevent Bolshevism from taking hold in this region.[6] Rulers who had fought to remove a British imperial stranglehold on their country were not about to simply replace that with Soviet dominance. Reza Khan, Amanullah, Gandhi and Kemal Ataturk may not have been particular friends of Britain, but neither were they prepared to become bed-fellows of Lenin.

Excellent Medicine

While Russia was being frustrated in its Communist plan for southern Asia, by 1922–1923 Britain appeared to be developing some breathing space from the rampant nationalism and pan-Islamism that had taken hold of the region in the post-war period. In Persia, for example, affairs were starting to stabilise for Britain, due, in no small part, to a change in Whitehall's policy towards that country; a shift from the more forward policy of Curzon to something more akin to the Indian government's point of view. Marking this new phase in Britain's relations with Persia was the appointment of Sir Percy Loraine as ambassador to Tehran in January 1922. Unfortunately for him, Herman Norman had never been very popular with Curzon. One cannot help but feel sorry for the hapless diplomat, stuck in a rather hopeless position in Tehran and seemingly never able to set a foot right in Curzon's eyes. In contrast, Loraine was to prove very popular with the foreign secretary and would cultivate a reputation 'as a brilliant manager of British interests'.[7] In fact, Curzon had wanted to appoint Loraine as Counsellor under Norman, but he had ended up serving in Poland instead. However, Curzon's high regard for Loraine remained and when Norman relinquished his position the foreign secretary was quick to offer it to Loraine, making him one of the youngest appointees to such a sensitive